

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

16th WEEK



JULIAN ASSANGE AND WIKILEAKS



Learning Space



NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

16th APRIL, 2019

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Secrets and agents

The arrest of Julian Assange raises fears about suppression of the right to information

The arrest of Julian Assange, the head of the anti-secrecy website WikiLeaks, has renewed a global debate on balancing freedom of expression (or the right to information) with considerations towards the national security of a country. After nearly seven years of eluding authorities in the U.S. and the U.K., facing charges related to theft of classified information from government computers, he was dragged out of the Ecuadorian Embassy in London on April 11 following Ecuador President Lenin Moreno's withdrawal of his country's grant of asylum to Mr. Assange, for "repeated violations to international conventions and duty-like protocols". Ecuador had earlier limited Mr. Assange's Internet access. As he sits in jail for up to a year on bail-jumping charges from 2012 in a now-closed case relating to sexual assault allegations by a complainant from Sweden, he will find out whether he will ultimately face the prospect of extradition to the U.S. There, Mr. Assange is looking at a single count of conspiring, with former U.S. Army intelligence officer Chelsea Manning, to break into a secret government computer network. Conspiracy charges, rather than those under the Espionage Act, are what he will likely face, given concerns in the U.K. that he should not be extradited to any country where the death penalty is applicable in his case.

At the heart of the drama is the question whether Mr. Assange is a "journalist" in the traditional sense of the word and whether, following that line of reasoning, freedom of expression is endangered or compromised by the action taken in this case. There is some irony in this debate given that the voices of liberal America are clamouring the loudest for his interrogation for the alleged crime of conspiracy, not so much in the case of the U.S. diplomatic cables or the dissemination of related top-secret U.S. government information – but owing to WikiLeaks being linked to rogue actors in Russia who allegedly pillooned Democratic Party documents and handed them over to Mr. Assange for use on his website, thereby tipping the scales in Donald Trump's favour in the 2016 election. Nevertheless, can WikiLeaks be considered a mainstream media organisation? Perhaps not. However, the arrest highlights troubling facts, including that the indictment against Mr. Assange, revealed only this month, appears to be flimsy, for it relates to a conversation he is alleged to have had nine years ago with Ms. Manning on a computer break-in attempt that ultimately failed. At a time when strongmen-led governments and resurgent nationalism are at the forefront of domestic politics in many countries, the arrest of a prominent anti-secrecy advocate is likely to have a chilling effect on whistle-blowers everywhere. That could ultimately weaken democracy itself.

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

1 Secrets and agents

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- Mr. Assange was arrested by British Police and carried out of the Ecuadorean Embassy after his South American hosts abruptly revoked his seven-year asylum.
- It paves the way for his extradition to the USA.
- He was facing charges relating to theft of classified information from Govt. computers.



The WikiLeaks founder is in custody in London awaiting sentencing for breaching his British bail conditions in 2012 by seeking refuge in the Ecuadorean embassy to avoid extradition to Sweden.





- *WikiLeaks is an international non-profit organisation that publishes secret information, news leaks and classified media provided by anonymous sources.*
- *Julian Assange, an Australian Internet activist, is generally described as its founder and director.*

VIENNA CONVENTION

1961 Vienna Convention sets out the rules governing consulates and embassies and guarantees the “inviolability” of diplomatic premises.

ASYLUM

Asylum, in international law, the protection granted by a state to a foreign citizen against his own State.

CLASSIFIED INFORMATION

Classified information is sensitive information to which access is restricted by law or regulation to particular classes of people.

WHY WILL HE BE EXTRADITED TO USA?



- 1** USA has alleged that Mr. Assange engaged in a 2010 conspiracy with Chelsea Manning.
- 2** Chelsea Manning served seven years in military prison for leaking classified data.
- 3** USA charged Assange with conspiracy to commit computer intrusion.

JULIAN ASSANGE ... TWO CONTRADICTIONS!



HERO ...

- He is a hero for exposing what supporters cast as abuse of power by the modern states.
- He is for championing free speech.

OR

... REBEL

- He is a dangerous rebel who undermined U.S. security.
- He published hundreds of thousands of secret U.S. diplomatic cables.
- They were highly critical of the world leaders.

WikiLeaks said Ecuador has illegally terminated his political asylum in violation of international law.

WHY ECUADOR WITHDRAWN ASYLUM?



- 1 Mr. Assange's relationship with his hosts collapsed after Ecuador accused him of leaking the information about President Lenin Moreno's personal life.
- 2 Mr. Moreno said Mr. Assange's diplomatic asylum has been cancelled for repeated violation of conventions.
- 3 He said that the WikiLeaks founder had tried to set up a "centre for spying" in Ecuador's London embassy.

WIKILEAKS LINKS WITH RUSSIA!



- 1 WikiLeaks is being linked to rogue actors in Russia.
- 2 They allegedly purloined (stole) Democratic Party documents and handed them over to Mr. Assange for use on his website.
- 3 It alleged to have tipped the scales in Donald Trump's favour in the 2016 elections.



HOW TO VIEW THIS DEVELOPMENT?



- 1 Now, it is the time of strongmen-led Governments and resurgent nationalism across the Globe.
- 2 The arrest of a prominent anti-secrecy advocate is likely to have a chilling effect on whistle-blowers everywhere.



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